

The 4 Disciplines of Execution (4DX)

A framework for turning strategy into results, in correlation with Chapter 10: Building an Organization Capable of Good Strategy Execution (Thompson, Peteraf, Gamble & Strickland, 2024)

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Strategy is the easy half. Execution is the hard half.

80%

of strategies fail in execution,
despite USD 30 bn+ spent
yearly on strategy creation
(FranklinCovey, 2024)

#1

challenge named by 400
CEOs in the US, Europe and
Asia: executional excellence
(Thompson et al., 2024, p.
295)

*“It’s been rather easy for
us to decide where we
wanted to go. The hard
part is to get the
organization to act on the
new priorities.”*

– Executive quoted in Thompson et
al. (2024, p. 295)

Chapter 10: “Whereas crafting strategy is largely an analysis-driven activity ... executing strategy is primarily operations-driven, revolving around the management of people, resources, business processes, and organizational structure.” (p. 295)

The question for today: what keeps operations-driven execution alive when daily work takes over?

Chapter 10 recap: organization-building tasks

Fig. 10.1 - Ten basic tasks of strategy execution (p. 298)

1. Staffing the organization	Ch. 10
2. Developing resources & capabilities	Ch. 10
3. Creating a strategy-supportive structure	Ch. 10
4. Allocating sufficient resources	Ch. 11
5. Instituting policies & procedures	Ch. 11
6. Adopting continuous-improvement processes	Ch. 11
7. Installing information & operating systems	Ch. 11
8. Tying rewards to performance	Ch. 11
9. Fostering a supportive culture	Ch. 12
10. Exerting strategic leadership	Ch. 12

Fig. 10.2 - Three key actions (p. 299)

1

Staffing

Strong management team; recruit, train and retain talent (pp. 300–304)

2

Capabilities

Build via internal development, M&A or partnerships; “a multistage process” (p. 305)

3

Structure

Outsource vs. in-house, structure type, centralize vs. delegate, cross-unit coordination (pp. 309–321)

The real enemy of execution: the whirlwind

The Whirlwind

- The massive energy needed just to keep the operation running day to day
- Urgent, unavoidable, and it always wins the fight for attention
- Not the villain: it keeps the company alive today

The Strategic Goals

- New initiatives that require behaviour change
- Important but not urgent, so they are postponed week after week
- Chapter 10: “when strategies fail, it is often because of poor execution” (p. 297)

4DX is designed to execute strategic goals in the midst of the whirlwind, not instead of it.

The 4 Disciplines at a glance

McChesney, Covey & Huling (2012), FranklinCovey. Applied with 140,000+ teams in 4,000+ implementations worldwide.

1

Focus on the Wildly Important

The discipline of focus

Narrow to 1-2 Wildly Important Goals (WIGs) per team

2

Act on the Lead Measures

The discipline of leverage

Work the few predictive, influenceable activities

3

Keep a Compelling Scoreboard

The discipline of engagement

People play differently when they keep score

4

Create a Cadence of Accountability

The discipline of accountability

A short weekly session of commitments and follow-through

1 Focus on the Wildly Important

Definition

- Select the one or two goals that would make the biggest difference if achieved; everything else stays in the whirlwind
- Rule: no team holds more than two WIGs at a time
- Every team WIG must translate into the WIG of the level above (line of sight from board to frontline)
- Leaders may veto, but teams choose their own WIG, which creates ownership

The WIG formula

From X → to Y by WHEN

A lag measure with a baseline, a target and a deadline

Example (regional expansion)

“Increase on-time delivery to Vietnam distributors from 82% to 95% by 31 December 2027.”

Measure: number of WIGs per team (max 2);
WIG statement complete (X, Y, when)

2

Act on the Lead Measures

	Lag measure	Lead measure
What it measures	The result you want (the WIG itself)	The activity that drives the result
Timing	Known only after the fact; history	Known now, weekly
Can the team move it directly?	No – it is an outcome	Yes – it must be influenceable
Predictive?	No – it is the goal	Yes – it must be predictive of the lag
Example	On-time delivery 82% → 95%	% of orders confirmed to forwarder within 24 h; weekly quality audits completed

The two tests of a good lead measure

Predictive

If it moves, the WIG moves.

Influenceable

The team can move it this week without waiting for anyone else.

Chapter 10 link

Lead measures are the routines that, repeated, become an organizational capability (p. 305).

3 Keep a Compelling Scoreboard

A players' scoreboard, not a coach's dashboard



Simple

A handful of numbers, not a 20-page report



Visible

Where the team works, updated by the team



Shows lead AND lag

The activity and the result, side by side



Tells you at a glance

Are we winning or losing? Answer in 5 seconds

Team scoreboard - WIG: on-time delivery
82% → 95%



Lead this week: **orders confirmed <24 h:**
46/50 (92%) | Status: winning

4 Create a Cadence of Accountability

The weekly WIG session: 20-30 minutes, same day, same time, never cancelled

1 Account

Each member reports on last week's commitments: done or not done, no excuses

2 Review the scoreboard

Learn from successes and failures; what moved the lead measure?

3 Plan

Each member makes 1-2 new commitments that will move the lead measure this week

Measures: session held every week (yes/no); % of commitments kept; week-on-week movement of the lead measure

Chapter 10 link: accountability is pushed to “the lowest organizational level capable of making timely, informed, competent decisions” (p. 318), and cross-unit coordination is achieved through a shared rhythm rather than more hierarchy (pp. 319-321).

Dimensions and measures of the model (summary)

Dimension	How it is defined	Key measure	Question it answers
1. Wildly Important Goal	1-2 goals per team, “from X to Y by when”, cascading to the organization’s WIG	Number of WIGs; lag measure with baseline, target, deadline	What matters most?
2. Lead measures	Activities that are predictive of the WIG and influenceable by the team	Weekly count or % of the lead activity	What must we do this week?
3. Compelling scoreboard	Simple, visible, shows lead and lag, tells at a glance if winning	Scoreboard meets 4 criteria; updated weekly	Are we winning?
4. Cadence of accountability	Weekly WIG session: account, review, commit	Session held; % commitments kept	Who does what by next week?

Source: McChesney, Covey & Huling (2012); FranklinCovey (2024).

How 4DX operationalizes Chapter 10

Chapter 10 action (Fig. 10.2, p. 299)	What the chapter says	What 4DX adds
1. Staffing the organization	Assemble “a critical mass of talented managers who can function as agents of change” (p. 301); recruit, train, retain	Weekly WIG sessions make performance visible: leaders see who delivers commitments and who needs coaching or reassignment
2. Building resources & capabilities	Capabilities grow through learning by doing, “a multistage process ... over months and years” (p. 305); execution capabilities are hard to imitate (p. 308)	Lead measures are the routines that become capabilities; repeating them weekly institutionalizes the competence
3. Structuring the organization & work effort	Match structure to strategy; delegate to the lowest competent level (p. 318); coordinate across units (pp. 319–321)	Teams own their WIG and lead measures; cascading WIGs create cross-unit alignment without new hierarchy

Chapter 10 defines the organizational conditions for execution; 4DX supplies the weekly behaviour that uses them.

Benefits in the context of international business

1 Focus across borders

The two-WIG rule stops initiative overload in matrix and multi-country organizations; every subsidiary aligns on the few goals that matter globally.

2 Common execution language

Lead measures and scoreboards translate across cultures; Jakarta and Dubai can be compared on the same behaviours.

3 Accountability at a distance

A 20-minute weekly WIG session works virtually and across time zones, a light governance rhythm for dispersed teams.

4 Global alignment, local fit

Headquarters sets the lag measure; each country team chooses its own lead measures using local market knowledge.

Reported results: Whirlpool +USD 5.7 m incremental in the first 90 days; DeKalb Medical patient satisfaction from the 3rd to the 99th percentile (FranklinCovey, 2024). Note: vendor-reported, not independently audited.

Illustration: Indonesian firm expanding to ASEAN

Hypothetical example: a Jakarta-based FMCG producer entering Vietnam and the Philippines. Strategy chosen (Ch. 7); Chapter 10 asks whether the organization can execute it.

Corporate WIG

Grow ASEAN export revenue from USD 12 m to USD 30 m by Dec 2028

Country team WIG (Vietnam)

Lift distributor on-time delivery from 82% to 95% by Dec 2027

Lead measures (weekly)

% of orders confirmed to forwarder within 24 h • Number of distributor visits by sales reps • Customs documents error-free on first submission

Scoreboard + WIG session

One shared board per country team; 20-minute Monday call across Jakarta, Ho Chi Minh City and Manila

Critical assessment of 4DX

Strengths

- Simple, teachable, works at frontline level
- Solves the 'whirlwind' problem that most planning tools ignore
- Builds execution capability, the hardest-to-copy advantage (Ch. 10, p. 308)
- Compatible with OKR, Balanced Scorecard and Hoshin Kanri as the weekly engine

Limitations

- Silent on strategy content: it executes a poor strategy just as faithfully
- Evidence base is mostly vendor case studies, not independent research
- Weekly cadence can decay into ritual reporting
- In high power-distance cultures (incl. Indonesia), admitting missed commitments in public needs psychological safety
- WIGs must be re-set when the environment shifts (Ch. 3), or discipline serves an outdated goal

Key takeaways

- 1 Execution, not strategy, is the number-one management challenge (Ch. 10, p. 295).
- 2 Chapter 10 builds the organization: people, capabilities, structure. 4DX makes that organization act, week by week.
- 3 Four dimensions, each with a measurable discipline: WIG, lead measures, scoreboard, cadence.
- 4 For international firms: focus, a common language, remote accountability, and local adaptation within global alignment.

References

FranklinCovey. (2024). The 4 Disciplines of Execution®. <https://www.franklincovey.com/the-4-disciplines/>

McChesney, C., Covey, S., & Huling, J. (2012). The 4 Disciplines of Execution: Achieving Your Wildly Important Goals. New York: Free Press.

Thompson, A. A., Peteraf, M. A., Gamble, J. E., & Strickland, A. J. (2024). Crafting & Executing Strategy: The Quest for Competitive Advantage (2024 Release), Ch. 10, pp. 294–325. McGraw Hill.